SRM VALLIAMMAI ENGINEERING COLLEGE

(Autonomous)

Department of English

Intellectual freedom (Quest 30) — Report

CANDIDATE INFORMATION

Student Name	kani vivi
Department	CSE-2
Quest	Intellectual freedom
Completed On	20/10/2026, 8:43:11 am

PERFORMANCE SUMMARY

Total Lines	23
Correct	23
Wrong Attempts	26
Gems	-3
Time	32m 12s

QUESTION BANK

Passage summary:

History repeatedly reminds us that progress begins with people who dare to think independently. Society often rewards conformity because agreement creates comfort, yet many of the world's greatest writers have argued that genuine growth begins when an individual develops the courage to trust reason rather than popularity. Ralph Waldo Emerson expressed this idea most powerfully in his essay Self-Reliance. He believed that a person's greatest strength lies not in wealth, status, or public approval but in character and conviction. His famous advice, "Trust thyself," encourages individuals to cultivate confidence in their own judgment. Elsewhere, he concludes that "Nothing can bring you peace but yourself. Nothing can bring you peace but the triumph of principles." For Emerson, success is not measured by possessions but by the integrity of one's beliefs. Henry David Thoreau transformed Emerson's philosophy into a way of life. Leaving behind the distractions of society, he sought simplicity at Walden Pond because he wished "to live deliberately." Thoreau believed that modern life often buries what truly matters beneath unnecessary ambition and endless consumption. A meaningful life, he argued, begins by separating genuine needs from artificial desires. More than two thousand years earlier, the Stoic philosopher Marcus Aurelius offered remarkably similar advice. He observed that "The happiness of your life depends upon the quality of your thoughts." Instead of attempting to control fortune or public opinion, he urged people to govern the only thing fully within their power—their own minds. True freedom, therefore, is an inner achievement rather than an external reward. The same spirit appears in the writings of Francis Bacon. His celebrated observation that "Reading maketh a full man" suggests that education should produce sound judgment rather than mere information. Knowledge, in Bacon's view, becomes valuable only when it strengthens wisdom and practical action. Although these writers lived in different centuries and cultures, they converge on a timeless principle: a fulfilled life cannot be borrowed from society. Wealth may disappear, popularity may fade, and public opinion may change overnight, but disciplined thinking, moral courage, and intellectual independence remain lasting possessions. Their message is neither to reject society nor to glorify isolation. Rather, it is to build an inner foundation so strong that one can cooperate with others without surrendering one's principles. In an age shaped by algorithms, social media, and constant comparison, their words remain a powerful reminder that the most important voice we must learn to hear is our own.